Worksheet W2 · W-Seminar "Time"

Research and writing guide

From a vague interest to a finished paper: sources, citing, thesis, structure, data – and actually getting started.

1 Find sources – and judge them

Where to search

- **Library catalogues**: school, city library, *Bayerische Staatsbibliothek* (OPAC)
- **Google Scholar**, JSTOR, open-access journals
- **Data**: Destatis, Our World in Data, Google Books Ngram Viewer
- **Primary texts**: Project Gutenberg (older literature)
- **Snowballing**: read the works cited of a good source

Search smarter English keywords · `"exact phrase"` · `filetype:pdf` · synonyms (*time perception / temporal judgement*)

The CRAAP test

C **Currency** – how recent? Does it matter for my topic?
R **Relevance** – does it answer *my* question?
A **Authority** – who wrote it? Expert, institution?
A **Accuracy** – evidence, sources, peer review?
P **Purpose** – inform, sell, persuade?

Wikipedia and AI chatbots are good *starting points* – not sources you cite.

2 Cite in MLA style (9th edition)

In the text

Author's surname + page, no comma:
… feel longer in memory (Hammond 47).

Quote short passages exactly, paraphrase the rest – **both** need a citation.

Tools Zotero (free, browser plug-in), MyBib, Citavi, Word ›References‹. Always check the result.

Works Cited – the core elements in this order

Author. *Title of Source*. *Title of Container*, Other contributors, Version, Number, Publisher, Publication date, Location.

Book Hammond, Claudia. *Time Warped: Unlocking the Mysteries of Time Perception*. Canongate, 2012.

Article Núñez, Rafael E., and Eve Sweetser. "With the Future Behind Them: Convergent Evidence from Aymara Language and Gesture in the Crosslinguistic Comparison of Spatial Construals of Time." *Cognitive Science*, vol. 30, no. 3, 2006, pp. 401–50.

AI "Explain Vierordt's law in two sentences" prompt. *ChatGPT*, version, OpenAI, 12 Mar. 2027, chatgpt.com.

3 From topic to thesis

Topic	→	Focus	→	Research question	→	Thesis / hypothesis
time perception		waiting time + music		Does fast music make waiting feel shorter?		With fast music, teens estimate waits as shorter.

A good research question is … **specific** (who, what, where), **researchable** with your means in a few months, **open** enough for a real answer, **relevant** – someone cares about the answer.

– What is time perception? (an encyclopaedia entry)
+ How does background music change how long Year 12 students think they waited?

Your turn – my question, version 0: topic → focus → question. Rough is fine – it will grow.

4 The structure of your Seminararbeit

Title page, Abstract	Abstract: 150–200 words – question, method, main result. Write it last.	½ p.
Contents	numbered headings (1, 1.1, 1.2 …) with page numbers	–
1 Introduction	hook, relevance, research question, thesis, how the paper is organised	1 p.
2 Background	key terms, theories and the state of research – *what do others already know?*	3–4 p.
3 Method	your design: material or participants, procedure, measures	1–2 p.
4 Results	tables and charts with short descriptions – no interpretation yet	2–3 p.
5 Discussion	what the results mean, limits of your study, link back to theory	2–3 p.
6 Conclusion	answer to the research question, outlook	1 p.
Works Cited, Appendix	all sources in MLA style; questionnaire, raw data, AI log, signed declaration	–

5 Get data you can actually use

Survey

- **Operationalise**: "feels long" → "How long did you wait? (in minutes)"
- mostly **closed questions**, scales from 1 to 5
- no leading or double questions:
  - Don't you agree that phones waste time and make us lazy?
- **pilot** with three people, then improve
- aim for **30+ answers per group**; anonymous

Experiment

- **one thing you change** (independent variable): music on / off
- **one thing you measure** (dependent variable): estimated waiting time
- **everything else stays the same**: room, instructions, real waiting time
- assign people to groups at **random**
- write down *exactly* what you did – others must be able to repeat it

Before you collect data in school: ask your teacher – surveys need permission from the school, and under-18s may need parental consent. Never collect names you don't need.

Make data usable

- **one row** per participant, **one column** per variable
- a **codebook**: what does each column and code mean?
- clean: incomplete answers out – and say how many
- **describe**: n, mean, median, standard deviation
- **show**: bar chart or boxplot per group
- correlation ≠ causation!

ID	group	age	estimate (s)
01	music	17	142
02	silence	18	205
03	music	17	131
…	…	…	…

Spreadsheet functions (English / German Excel):
AVERAGE / MITTELWERT · MEDIAN · STDEV.S / STABW.S · CORREL / KORREL

Your turn: What could you measure for your idea – and what would you change?

6 Start writing – before you feel ready

1 Dump 10 min stream of thought: write everything you know or think. No deleting. → **2 Cluster** mark what belongs together with colours, cross out the rest. → **3 Order** turn the clusters into an outline – headings and bullet points. → **4 Elaborate** one bullet at a time: explain, add evidence, cite.

- The first draft is **allowed to be ugly**. Editing is easier than starting.
- Start where it is easiest – often **method** or **results**. Write the introduction last.
- **Fixed slot**: same day, same time, every week. 25 minutes on, 5 off.
- **Snapshot about every 4 weeks**: hand in your current state, however rough (box 7).
- End each session with **one sentence for next time**: "Next: …"
- Keep your **research log** and **AI log** up to date as you go.
- Stuck? Explain your idea aloud to someone in two minutes – then write down what you said.

My weekly writing slot: _____

7 Plan backwards from the hand-in date: my milestones

by (date)	milestone	done
end of 12/1	topic and first research question fixed	☐
every ~4 weeks	snapshot: hand in my current dump / outline / draft	☐
		☐
early Nov 2027	**hand in the Seminararbeit**	☐